

Versus as Attractor: Trump, Override, and the Politics Without a Ground State

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Abstract

Ordinary political displacement has a ground state: the system was designed for S_0 and drifted to S^* . Versus-politics is a stranger object. Its attractor is opposition itself. The system is not displaced from a ground state; it is constituted by displacement against an enemy. Trump names this structure three times over: the man whose politics is pure versus, the card that overrides every suit, the verb that wins without resolving. A versus-system cannot return to S_0 because it never had one. Remove the enemy and it does not heal; it collapses, or finds a new enemy.

1 Trump Equals Versus

In a card game, a trump beats any card of any other suit. It does not engage the grammar of the trick—which suit was led, which card is higher within it. It overrides the grammar. Trumping is the operation that wins without resolving.

The framework knows one way to cross incompatible grammars: resonance. Find the shared frequency, the structure both grammars can inhabit. Expensive

to find, slow to build—though once built, return becomes cheap—and it actually crosses the wall.

Override is resonance’s counterfeit, and this paper’s name for the alternative: declare your move superior regardless of suit. Cheap, instant, and it crosses nothing. The incompatibility is not resolved; it is suppressed. The suppressed grammar persists, and accumulates.

Versus-politics is politics conducted entirely by override.

2 The Attractor With No Ground

Standard political displacement: democracy is the expensive intended ground state S_0 ; power concentrates because concentration is cheaper; the system stabilizes at S^* and the return cost grows. The displaced system is still oriented—it knows what it fell away from.

Versus-politics has a different topology. Its stable state is not a position but a relation: *against*. The identity is defined by what it opposes, so the opponent is load-bearing. The enemy is not an obstacle between the system and its ground state; the enemy is the foundation.

This is displacement without origin. There is no S_0 to return to, because nothing was ever intended except the opposition itself. The framework’s universality survives: the polity beneath still has a ground state. What the versus-movement lacks is any orientation to it—identity fused with attractor, taken to the limit, where C_{return} is not prohibitive but undefined.

3 Why Versus Is Cheap

Opposition is the cheapest political structure available:

- It requires no construction. Negation is free; the other side does the work of defining you.
- It is self-renewing. Every move the enemy makes feeds the identity.

- It needs no internal coherence. A versus-coalition can contain contradictions indefinitely, because its only invariant is the direction it points.

A politics of S_0 must maintain something: institutions, procedure, a shared world. A politics of versus maintains only the enemy. The cost differential drives the whole system toward versus, on every side. Opposition begets opposition; the attractor is symmetric and self-deepening.

4 Who Pays

The notation needs two levels. The polity has a ground state: the commons, the shared grammar of facts, procedure, and trust. Versus-politics is the polity's S^* ; only the movement qua identity has no ground of its own. So $D(\xi)$ is well-defined—and paid by neither side. Both sides are stable—the deeper the conflict, the more stable. The cost is externalized onto the commons that both sides override on the way to winning.

Each trump play wins the trick and degrades the game. The suppressed grammars do not disappear. They accumulate as return debt in the one place that has no advocate: the common world that versus-politics needs to fight over but cannot afford to maintain.

5 The Impossible Return

A displaced democracy can in principle return: the ground state is known, the cost is merely prohibitive. A versus-system cannot, structurally. Two outcomes are available when the enemy is removed:

- Collapse. The identity loses its load-bearing wall. - Substitution. A new enemy is found, often internal, often smaller. The system fragments along ever-finer lines of versus.

This is why defeating a versus-movement never ends it, and why versus-

movements eat themselves when they win. The attractor was never the victory. The attractor was the against.

6 The Phronesis

The practical wisdom here is diagnostic. Ask of any political identity: what does it maintain? If the answer is a world—institutions, procedures, a ground state it could describe without mentioning its enemy—it is displaced at worst. If the answer is an enemy, it is versus, and no victory, compromise, or defeat will return it to a ground it never had.

The only exit from versus is the expensive one: resonance. Build the shared frequency, pay the full cost of an actual ground state. Trump is what winning looks like when no one will pay for the game.